THE

GULF JOB PLAYBOOK

2027

How to get a legal job in the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Kuwait, Oman or Bahrain from India — and come home with the money

Every fee an agent may charge. Every document you actually need. Every clause that decides what you get paid. The gratuity maths for all six countries, and the rescue sequence if it goes wrong.

INCLUDES

The Rs. 30,000 fee ceiling and what to do when an agent asks for more | ECR, eMigrate and PBBY, explained without jargon | A clause-by-clause contract read | Eleven scams in the order they arrive | NRE, NRO, LRS and the 182-day tax line | Eight printable worksheets and a 30-day plan

2027 EDITION · RULES CURRENT TO NOVEMBER 2026

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The Gulf Job Playbook 2027

Digital Edition · Rules current to November 2026

This book exists because most people who lose money on a Gulf job lose it in the first four weeks, before they ever board a plane — to a fee that was illegal, a document that was forged, a contract they could not read, or a visit visa sold as a work visa. By the time they land, the expensive decisions are already behind them. So this is a book about the sequence, not the destination.

It is written for the person doing this for the first time: the electrician from Bihar, the staff nurse from Kerala, the accountant from Hyderabad, the welder from Punjab, the fresh diploma holder from Tamil Nadu, and the parent who is paying for all of it. Every rule here comes from an official source — the Ministry of External Affairs and its eMigrate portal, the UAE Government portal and MoHRE, Saudi Arabia's Ministry of Human Resources, Qatar's labour law, and the labour ministries of Kuwait, Oman and Bahrain. Where a number changes often, the book tells you which page to check it on rather than pretending it never moves.

It does not promise a job, an interview, a visa or a salary. Nobody selling you those should be trusted. It promises something narrower and more useful: that you will know what is legal, what is normal, what is a warning sign, and what to do next.

HOW TO USE IT

If you are starting from zero, read Part 1 and Part 2 in order and skip nothing. If you already have an offer in hand, jump to Chapter 10 (the contract), then read the chapter for your destination country, then Chapter 18 (scams). If you are already abroad and stuck, go straight to Chapter 19 and work the sequence line by line.

A NOTE ON HONESTY

Nothing in this book is legal advice for your specific case, and it is not a substitute for the labour office or your embassy. Rules in the Gulf change by decree, sometimes overnight — a fee, a threshold or a fine quoted here may already have moved. Every chapter ends with the official page where the current version lives. Check it before you pay anyone.

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PART ONE

The decision, made with numbers

Four chapters before you speak to a single agent: what the market looks like in 2026–27, how the six countries differ on the things that decide your life, what the trip actually costs, and what you will realistically save. Most people skip this part and pay for it later.

CHAPTER 1

The Gulf still hires Indians — but not the same Indians

About 7.6 million Indians live and work in the six Gulf states, out of roughly 13.2 million Indians abroad — well over half of the entire Indian diaspora sits in one corner of the world. In 2025 the Ministry of External Affairs recorded about 449,110 emigration clearances for Emigration Check Required passport holders, the highest since 2016. The Gulf is not a rumour or a scam. It is the largest organised labour market India has.

The shape of that market has changed, though, and the change is what should drive your decision this year. Through the first half of 2026, hiring in the UAE contracted sharply — the NaukriGulf Hiring Index reported a 23% year-on-year fall in overall UAE hiring activity in the April–May 2026 window, with retail and commercial construction among the hardest hit, while Saudi Arabia grew over the same period. By early 2026 the UAE had overtaken Saudi Arabia as the top destination for Indian blue-collar workers. Both statements are true at once, and the gap between them is where most bad decisions get made.

7.6 M
INDIANS IN THE GCC
Over half of India's 13.2 million-strong diaspora

449,110
CLEARANCES IN 2025
ECR emigration clearances, highest since 2016

-23%
UAE HIRING, Q2 2026
Year-on-year fall in overall UAE hiring activity

What the numbers actually tell you

A falling hiring index does not mean nobody is hiring. It means the queue got longer and the employer got pickier, which changes the economics of the trip in three specific ways.

- **The visa you are offered gets worse.** When employers have choice, they push cost and risk onto the worker: shorter contracts, lower basic pay with allowances inflated to make the offer look bigger, and more willingness to hire on a visit visa and regularise later. Every one of those is a red flag in Chapter 10.
- **The middleman gets more aggressive.** A tight market is the middleman's best market, because he can promise a job that does not exist and still find takers. The 2026 advisories from Indian missions and the MEA's own statements about trafficking networks using fake Gulf offers are aimed at exactly this window.
- **Salary offers stop tracking the market.** When hiring slows, employers cut the offer, not the workload. The only defence is knowing the market rate before you negotiate — Chapter 11 shows how to price yourself in twenty minutes.

Where the demand has moved

Saudi Arabia's growth is not evenly spread. The giga-projects and the services build-out around them pull in engineers, safety officers, quantity surveyors, welders, heavy equipment operators, HVAC technicians and site supervisors, and the hiring runs through large contractors rather than small trading firms. The UAE's contraction has been sharpest in retail and commercial fit-out, and milder in healthcare, facilities management, logistics and the free-zone professional services that serve the region rather than the local consumer.

Qatar, Kuwait, Oman and Bahrain are smaller, steadier markets with their own rhythms: Qatar's post-World-Cup construction has cooled but its healthcare, education and hospitality hiring continues; Kuwait's public-sector-heavy economy hires expatriates mostly through contractors and domestic work; Oman and Bahrain hire in smaller volumes and lean hardest on nationalisation quotas, which is why the same job title can be open in Muscat and closed in Manama.

THE 2026–27 REALITY IN ONE LINE

The Gulf is a buyer's market right now. That does not make it a bad market — it makes the paperwork and the contract the only things standing between you and a bad deal. Read Part 2 before you pay anyone anything.

Who should not go this year

This book is not a recruitment advertisement, so here is the honest list. You should not take a Gulf job this year if the offer requires you to borrow more than roughly four months of the salary you have been promised in order to travel; if the contract is with a company you cannot find registered anywhere; if the job title is vague (“supervisor”, “helper”, “staff”) and the employer will not name the site; or if you are being asked to travel on a visit visa and “convert later”. Those four conditions account for most of the losses reported to Indian missions each year.

There is also a category the market rarely discusses: the person who is already earning well in India. If your Indian salary is Rs. 45,000 a month and the Gulf offer is Rs. 65,000 with free accommodation, the arithmetic in Chapter 4 often shows a lower savings rate than staying — because the Gulf is not cheaper, it is simply denominated in a currency that converts well. Run the model before you resign.

CHAPTER 2

Six countries, one grid: what actually differs

There is no Gulf labour law. There are six, and they disagree on the two things that decide your money: how your end-of-service payment is calculated, and how easily you can change employers. Everything else — leave, notice, probation — matters, but those two decide whether three years in the Gulf leaves you with a lump sum or with nothing.

	UAE	Saudi Arabia	Qatar	Kuwait	Oman	Bahrain
Law	Federal Decree-Law 33/2021	Royal Decree M/51, amended 19 Feb 2025	Law 14/2004, amended by Law 9/2026	Law 6/2010	Royal Decree 53/2023	Law 36/2012
Probation	6 months	180 days total	6 months	100 working days	3 months (monthly paid)	3 months
Notice	30–90 days	60 days (employer, monthly)	1 month, then 2 after 2 yrs	3 months (monthly paid)	30 days	30 days
Annual leave	30 days	21 days, 30 after 5 yrs	3 weeks, 4 after 5 yrs	30 working days	30 days	30 days
End of service	21 days' basic × 5 yrs, then 30 days	Half month × 5 yrs, then 1 month	At least 3 weeks' basic per year	15 days × 5 yrs, then 1 month	At least 1 basic wage per year	Funded monthly via SIO
Wage base	Basic only	Full wage with allowances	Basic only	Wage with allowances	Basic only	Contract wage
Minimum wage	None in private sector	None for expatriates	QAR 1,000 + 500 + 300	KD 75	Set for Omanis	None in private sector
Change employer	After contract term or by mutual transfer	After 1 yr, or by Qiwa transfer	No exit permit needed; transfer with notice	1 yr, relaxed in listed cases (2026)	Permitted with clearance	Second job allowed, 3 months (2026)

Read the wage base column twice

The UAE, Qatar and Oman calculate your gratuity on **basic salary only**. Saudi Arabia, Kuwait and Bahrain calculate it on the **full wage including allowances**. This single difference can be worth a year's savings, and it is invisible unless you look at the split between basic and allowances in your contract.

A UAE offer of AED 6,000 a month might be structured as AED 3,000 basic, AED 1,500 housing, AED 900 transport and AED 600 other. Your gratuity is built on the 3,000, not the 6,000 — so five years of service produces about AED 26,250, not AED 52,500. The same total pay in Saudi Arabia produces roughly twice the end-of-service award, because the award counts the allowances. When you negotiate in the UAE, negotiate the basic.

> **THE NEGOTIATION THAT PAYS BEST**
>
> In a UAE or Qatar offer, a 10% increase in basic salary is worth more over five years than a 10% increase in total pay, because it lifts both the gratuity base and the overtime rate. Ask for the increase in basic; accept an increase in allowances only if the basic stays where it is.

The three countries that behave differently

Qatar is the only Gulf state with a genuinely non-discriminatory minimum wage, set in 2020 and still quoted in 2026 as QAR 1,000 basic plus QAR 500 for housing and QAR 300 for food where the employer does not provide them. Almost every article online compresses that into “Qatar's minimum wage is QAR 1,800”. It is not a single number; it is three, and the allowances are only owed if the employer does not provide housing and food in kind. Know which version your contract uses.

Kuwait sets a private-sector minimum wage of KD 75 a month — a floor so low that it protects almost nobody, but it is a floor, and it is the only other one in the region. Bahrain moved its expatriate end-of-service money into a monthly fund: since 1 March 2024 the employer pays 4.2% of wage into the Social Insurance Organisation for the first three years and 8.4% after, and the SIO pays you at the end. That is good news — your money is being set aside monthly instead of accumulating as a promise — but only if you check the contributions were actually made.

Oman is the timing trap. Expatriates still earn at least one basic wage per year of service under Article 61 of Royal Decree 53/2023, but a 9% employer-funded savings system is due to replace it no later than 19 July 2027. If you start an Omani contract in 2027, ask which system you are under before you sign — the answer changes what you receive at the end and when.

CHAPTER 3

What the trip really costs — and the fee that is illegal

The Ministry of External Affairs has capped what a registered recruiting agent may charge a worker for an overseas placement at Rs. 30,000 plus GST. That is the ceiling for the agent's service charge, and it is the single most useful number in this book, because the most common way Indians lose money on a Gulf job is an agent charging three to ten times that and calling it a visa fee, a processing fee, a ticket deposit or a “company charge”.

The cap applies to registered agents. It does not make every other cost disappear: passport, medicals, attestation, insurance, air ticket and the cash you carry are real and mostly unavoidable. What the cap does is draw a line you can hold in an argument. Anything charged above it, without a receipt that names the service, is a complaint you can file on eMigrate or with the Protector of Emigrants — and increasingly, a criminal matter.

The honest cost sheet

Below is what a first-time emigrant typically spends, with the range seen across Indian states. Treat the ranges as planning numbers, not quotes: passport and medical fees are fixed by government, attestation varies by document and state, and the ticket depends entirely on the season.

Item	Typical range	Who should pay	Watch for
Passport (fresh, 36 pages)	Rs. 1,500–2,000	You	Tatkal roughly doubles it
Medical (approved centre)	Rs. 1,500–4,500	You, sometimes employer	Some GCC employers reimburse; ask in writing
Degree / certificate attestation	Rs. 3,000–12,000	You	Chain must be notary, then MEA, then destination embassy
PCC (police clearance)	Rs. 500–1,000	You	Needed by several employers
PBBY insurance (ECR)	Rs. 275 for 2 yrs, Rs. 375 for 3 yrs	You	Mandatory, and cheap
Recruiting agent service charge	Up to Rs. 30,000 + GST	You (legally capped)	Any demand above this is the complaint
Air ticket	Rs. 12,000–35,000	Employer, per MEA contract norms	If you pay it, get it in the contract
First-month cash on landing	Rs. 15,000–40,000	You	Salary can lag 30–45 days behind arrival

Add it up for a typical Kerala or Bihar first-timer going to the UAE through a registered agent: somewhere between Rs. 55,000 and Rs. 95,000 all-in, of which the agent's legal share is under a third. If your total is above Rs. 1.5 lakh for a job paying under Rs. 40,000 a month, you are almost certainly paying for something that is not a lawful charge — and Chapter 18 explains what happens next.

THE RECEIPT RULE

Pay nothing without a receipt that names the service, the amount, the date, the agent's registration number and GST. If the agent will not give one, the charge is not lawful and the money is not recoverable. This is not bureaucratic fussiness — the receipt is the only evidence you will have when you file a complaint from 3,000 km away.

What the employer is supposed to pay

Under the emigration framework, the foreign employer bears the cost of the return air ticket and, in most cases, the visa and work-permit costs in the destination country. Indian norms also require the employer to provide the ticket for the initial journey in the standard contract. In practice, many employers quietly transfer these costs to the worker through the agent. You will not win that argument at the airport, so have it before you sign: ask for the ticket clause and the visa-cost clause to be written into the contract, and walk away if they refuse. A company that will not put a ticket in writing is telling you what it thinks of its obligations.

The borrow question

Most first-time emigrants borrow. That is normal and not automatically a mistake, but the loan should pass three tests. It should be smaller than four months of the promised net salary, so that a two-month salary delay does not become a crisis. It should not be from a moneylender at monthly interest, because 5% a month on Rs. 80,000 is Rs. 4,000 a month — roughly a fifth of a Rs. 20,000 salary — and it will follow you abroad. And it should be documented, because an undocumented loan against family property is how families lose the property.

WORKSHEET 1 — THE COST-TO-GO SHEET

Fill this before you agree to anything. If the total column exceeds four months of promised net salary, stop and renegotiate the route.

Passport and medical
Attestation and PCC
PBBY and insurance
Agent service charge (legal ceiling Rs. 30,000 + GST)
Air ticket — and who is paying
First-month cash on landing
Loan taken, and monthly repayment
TOTAL COST TO BOARD THE PLANE
Promised net monthly salary ÷ 4 = my safe borrowing limit

CHAPTER 4

What you will actually save: the three-year model

The offer letter quotes a salary. What matters is the savings rate — the gap between what lands in your account and what leaves it, after rent, food, transport, the phone, the remittance home and the small humiliations of living alone. Two people on the same salary can finish three years with Rs. 4 lakh and Rs. 14 lakh respectively, and the difference is almost never discipline. It is housing and the structure of the offer.

The model, worked

Take a UAE offer of AED 5,000 a month total, structured as AED 2,500 basic, AED 1,500 housing allowance and AED 1,000 transport and other. Assume shared accommodation at AED 1,200, food at AED 900, transport at AED 300, phone and internet at AED 150, and AED 1,500 sent home each month. That leaves AED 950 a month, or about Rs. 22,000 at Rs. 23 to the dirham — roughly Rs. 2.6 lakh a year before gratuity.

Line	Monthly (AED)	Yearly (AED)	Yearly (Rs. at 23)
Total salary	5,000	60,000	13,80,000
Rent (shared)	1,200	14,400	3,31,200
Food	900	10,800	2,48,400
Transport	300	3,600	82,800
Phone, internet, misc.	150	1,800	41,400
Remitted home	1,500	18,000	4,14,000
Left in hand	950	11,400	2,62,200

Now add the end-of-service gratuity: 21 days' basic per year for the first five years, which for a AED 2,500 basic is about AED 1,458 a year, so roughly AED 4,375 after three years. That is the entire gratuity — about Rs. 1 lakh. On this structure, three years in the UAE produces around Rs. 8.8 lakh in total savings. Real, but not the transformation people imagine.

Restructure the same AED 5,000 so the basic is AED 3,500 and the allowances are smaller, and the gratuity becomes AED 2,042 a year, AED 6,125 after three years. Same pay, Rs. 40,000 more at the end, purely from where the number sits in the contract. This is why Chapter 10 spends an entire section on the basic-allowance split.

> **THE FIVE-YEAR VERSION IS THE ONE THAT CHANGES A FAMILY**
>
> Most people leave at year two or three, right before the gratuity curve steepens. In the UAE the rate rises from 21 days to 30 days of basic per year after year five; in Saudi Arabia from half a month to a full month. If you are going to stay, stay past the step. If you are not, plan the exit from day one and treat gratuity as a bonus, not a plan.

The three variables you control

- **Housing.** Employer-provided accommodation is worth more than the allowance it replaces, because the allowance is taxable-in-practice (it is spent) while free accommodation usually also means free utilities and no deposit. A shared room in a labour camp at AED 500 a month versus a studio at AED 3,500 is a Rs. 7 lakh difference over three years.
- **The remittance rate.** Not the exchange rate — the frequency and the fee. Sending Rs. 40,000 once a month costs less in fees than four transfers of Rs. 10,000, and the discipline of a fixed transfer date beats sending “whatever is left”, which is usually nothing. Chapter 26 covers the channels.

- **Whether the family back home has a plan for the money.** This is the least discussed and most consequential variable. Money that arrives with no destination gets spent. A one-page agreement — so much for the loan, so much into a fixed deposit, so much for the house — is worth more than a raise.

The comparison you should actually make

Do not compare the Gulf salary to your Indian salary. Compare the savings rate to the savings rate, and the time to a specific goal to the time to that goal. If your goal is Rs. 10 lakh for a house, and staying in India saves Rs. 12,000 a month while the Gulf offer saves Rs. 25,000 a month, the Gulf saves you roughly 34 months. If the Gulf offer saves Rs. 14,000 because rent is high and the family travels with you, the Gulf saves you almost nothing and costs you three years of your child's childhood. That is the whole calculation, and nobody else can run it for you.

WORKSHEET 2 — THREE-YEAR SAVINGS PROJECTION

One column per offer you are considering. Use net figures only.

Total monthly salary (net of deductions)
Rent actually payable by me
Food, transport, phone, utilities
Money I will send home each month
Left in hand each month × 12
End-of-service after 3 years (see country chapter)
TOTAL SAVED IN 3 YEARS
The specific goal this money buys

PART TWO

The legal route out of India

Six chapters on the machinery nobody explains: the stamp on your passport, the portal that decides whether you leave at all, the fee that is capped by law, the insurance you already paid for, the documents that must be attested in a specific order, and the contract that decides what you actually earn.

CHAPTER 5

ECR: the stamp on your passport that changes everything

Open your passport to the page with your photograph. Look for a stamp or endorsement reading “ECR” or “Emigration Check Required”. If it is there, you cannot legally fly to any of the 18 notified ECR countries for work without an emigration clearance from a Protector of Emigrants. If it is not there — if your passport shows ECNR, or nothing at all — that requirement does not apply to you. The two categories are treated completely differently by everyone from the airline counter to the employer's HR department, and most people do not know which one they are.

ECR is not a punishment and not a mark of suspicion. It is an administrative category applied mainly to applicants who have not passed Class 10, and the reasoning behind it was protection: workers with fewer formal qualifications were judged more vulnerable to exploitation and were therefore routed through a checkpoint. In practice the checkpoint is also where your insurance, your contract and your employer's registration get looked at by a government officer before you leave, which is why losing it is not always a gain.

All six Gulf states are on the ECR list

The Ministry of External Affairs currently notifies 18 ECR countries, and all six GCC states — the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Kuwait, Oman and Bahrain — are among them. So for the purposes of this book, assume the rule applies: if your passport says ECR, you need clearance, whichever of the six you are flying to. The list has been revised more than once (Maldives was added, and older MEA pages still show 17 countries), so check the current list on the eMigrate portal rather than trusting any article, including this one, for the exact count.

If your passport says	What it means for a Gulf job	What you must do
ECR	Emigration clearance required before departure	Register on eMigrate, get clearance from the POE, buy PBBY insurance
ECNR	No emigration clearance required	No POE clearance, but the contract and insurance checks still make sense
Nothing / blank	Usually treated as ECNR	Confirm with the passport office if unsure

How ECNR is granted

The standard route to ECNR is qualification: a pass in Class 10 or above, evidenced by a certificate. Applicants who hold a diploma or degree, who have stayed abroad for a qualifying period, or who are income-tax payers can also fall outside ECR. If you qualify, you can apply for a re-issue of the passport with ECNR endorsement rather than travelling on an ECR passport — but weigh the time cost. A re-issue takes weeks, and if a genuine job offer is waiting, the clearance route is usually faster than the passport route.

DO NOT BUY AN ECNR STAMP

There is no market for ECNR endorsements, and anyone offering to “arrange” one for a fee is committing forgery. A forged endorsement discovered at immigration ends the job, the trip and possibly your ability to travel for years. If you qualify, apply properly; if you do not, take the clearance.

Two protections written into the clearance system

The emigration clearance rules carry two conditions that surprise people at the POE counter. First, women below the age of 30 are not granted emigration clearance for work in ECR countries under the current guidelines — a rule that exists to curb trafficking and that has no workaround. Second, for unskilled workers, farm workers and women emigrants, the employment agreement must be attested by the Indian embassy in the destination country. Both conditions are published in the MEA's own guidelines for the emigration clearance system, and both are checked before the sticker goes on.

If you are a woman under 30 with a Gulf offer, get advice from the Protector of Emigrants office or the OWRC helpline before paying any agent. There are lawful routes — a work visa obtained directly from a licensed employer, or a re-issued passport with ECNR where you qualify — but an agent who says “no problem, we will manage it” is describing a forged clearance, and you will be the one removed from the flight.

CHAPTER 6

eMigrate: the one screen that decides whether you leave

eMigrate is the Ministry of External Affairs' portal for overseas employment. It holds the register of licensed recruiting agents, the demand letters foreign employers have filed, the insurance records and the complaints. If you use one website in this entire process, use this one: emigrate.gov.in.

There are two ways to reach a Gulf employer, and both run through the portal. You can go through a registered recruiting agent, who must have a demand letter and power of attorney from the foreign employer and must file your details. Or you can be recruited directly by the employer, in which case you register yourself on eMigrate and apply for clearance directly. The second route is cheaper and increasingly common for nurses, engineers and IT staff; the first is how most blue-collar hiring still works.

The five-minute agent check

Before you hand over a single document, do this. Open the eMigrate portal and look up the agent's registration number. Confirm the name on the licence matches the name on the office board, the name on the receipt and the name on the WhatsApp message. Then check the MEA's list of blacklisted agents — it exists precisely because registration is not permanent, and an agent whose licence has been suspended may still be advertising.

1. Ask for the agent's registration number in writing, on the letterhead.
2. Search that number on eMigrate. Confirm status is active, not suspended or expired.
3. Confirm the employer's name on the demand letter matches the offer letter.
4. Ask which Protector of Emigrants office the clearance will be filed through.
5. Ask for the PBBY policy number before you pay the ticket, not after.

A registered agent will answer all five without irritation. An unregistered one will answer the first two and then become busy. That change in tone is the most reliable signal in the entire process.

> **THE SUB-AGENT PROBLEM**
>
> Most fraud happens one layer below the licensed agent. The licensed agent files the paperwork; a chain of sub-agents in your district collects the money and the passport. The licence protects the government's record, not your cash. Insist that every rupee goes to the licensed entity's bank account, and that the receipt is issued by that entity — never by an individual, never in cash without a numbered receipt.

What the Protector of Emigrants actually checks

The POE is not a rubber stamp. Under the published guidelines the officer verifies that the visa is genuine and valid for the stated period, that the employer's demand letter and power of attorney exist, that the employment contract carries the employer's seal and signature and has been given to the worker with a receipt, that the worker has been trade-tested for the job, that the salary meets the minimum standard in the specimen contract, and that PBBY insurance is in place. The officer can refuse clearance if the terms are discriminatory or exploitative, if the living or working conditions are sub-standard, or if there is no provision for repatriation.

This matters to you for a practical reason: the POE refusal is the last free check in the system. If your file is thin, the officer will find it. Bring originals, bring the contract you actually signed, and do not let an agent “handle” the interview on your behalf — you are the one who has to answer questions about your own job.

CHAPTER 7

The Rs. 30,000 rule: what an agent may charge, and what is extortion

The MEA's advisory on overcharging caps a registered recruiting agent's service charge at Rs. 30,000 plus GST per placement. Indian missions in the Gulf have issued the same advisory repeatedly, in the same words, because the same complaint keeps arriving: a worker who paid Rs. 1.2 lakh for a job that pays Rs. 18,000 a month and cannot recover a rupee of it.

Read the cap correctly. It is a ceiling on the agent's service charge, not on your total cost of travel. Passport fees, medicals, attestation, insurance and the air ticket sit outside it. What the cap does is make the arithmetic visible: if an agent's demand exceeds Rs. 30,000 plus GST, the excess is not a service charge under any name, and the name it is given tells you what kind of operation you are dealing with.

The vocabulary of overcharging

What they call it	What it usually is	What the law says
“Visa charge”	The employer's work-permit cost, moved to you	Employer's cost under the standard contract
“Ticket deposit”	Your own air ticket, paid twice	Employer provides initial ticket in the specimen contract
“Company charge”	A kickback to the sub-agent	Not a lawful charge at all
“Medical and clearance”	Real costs, inflated 3–5 times	Real cost is Rs. 1,500–4,500
“Salary security”	A bond with no legal basis	No such instrument exists
“Government file charge”	Fabricated	Government fees are paid against a challan, in your name

What a clean payment looks like

- One bank transfer, to the licensed entity's account, with the registration number in the narration.
- One GST invoice showing the service charge, the tax, and the total — not a handwritten slip.
- Separate receipts for the costs you paid at cost: medical, attestation, insurance.
- No cash to an individual, ever, for anything above a few hundred rupees.
- The PBBY policy number and the insurer's name, in writing, before departure.

If you have already paid and the amounts do not reconcile, you have two routes: a complaint on eMigrate, or a complaint to the Protector General of Emigrants with the receipts attached. Both are free. Neither requires a lawyer. The OWRC helpline 1800-11-3090 will talk you through the filing in your own language, twenty-four hours a day — it operates in eleven Indian languages.

> **THE SENTENCE THAT ENDS MOST NEGOTIATIONS WELL**
>
> “Please give me the GST invoice with your registration number, and I will transfer to the company account.” An agent who is operating legally hears nothing unusual. An agent who is not will invent a reason why an invoice is difficult — and you will have learned what you needed to know, for free.

CHAPTER 8

PBBY: the Rs. 275 policy almost nobody claims

The Pravasi Bharatiya Bima Yojana is the cheapest meaningful financial protection an Indian emigrant can buy, and it is compulsory for ECR workers. It provides an insurance cover of Rs. 10 lakh for accidental death or permanent disability, at a premium of Rs. 275 for two years or Rs. 375 for three. It also covers medical expenses and repatriation of remains, and since the 2017 revision it applies globally, irrespective of employer or location.

Read that again: ten lakh rupees of cover, for the price of a train ticket. Then consider that most workers who hold the policy cannot tell you the insurer's name, do not know the policy number, and have never told their family the policy exists. When the worst happens, the family is usually the last to know there was any cover at all. That gap between the policy and the claim is the real story of PBBY.

Who must have it, and who should anyway

For ECR passport holders going to an ECR country for employment, PBBY is mandatory and the policy is one of the documents the Protector of Emigrants checks before granting clearance. The 2017 scheme was also made compulsory for various work categories under Section 2(o) of the Emigration Act, irrespective of passport category. If you are ECNR, nobody will stop you at the airport for not having it — and you should buy it anyway, because Rs. 375 for three years is less than a month of a phone bill.

Feature	What PBBY 2017 provides
Cover	Rs. 10 lakh for accidental death or permanent disability
Premium	Rs. 275 for 2 years; Rs. 375 for 3 years
Medical	Hospitalisation cover for the insured worker, per scheme terms
Repatriation	Cost of transporting mortal remains to India
Scope	Global, irrespective of employer or location
Renewal	Online renewal available
Claim route	Simplified certification of accidental death or permanent disability

The three things to do before you fly

1. Get the policy document, not just a number. Photograph every page and send it to two family members and to your own email.
2. Write the insurer's name, the policy number, the start and end dates and the claim helpline on one sheet of paper and leave it with your family in India — not in your suitcase.
3. Set a reminder 45 days before expiry. Renewal is online, but it is not automatic, and a lapsed policy on the day of an accident pays nothing.

> **WHERE CLAIMS ACTUALLY FAIL**
>
> Claims fail for three reasons: the policy had lapsed, the family could not find the policy, or the cause of death or injury was not certified in the form the insurer requires. All three are preventable with one photograph and one calendar reminder. Do it now, before you read the next chapter.

CHAPTER 9

Documents: the order of attestation is the whole game

Gulf employers ask for a set of documents that has not changed much in twenty years, and the failure mode has not changed either: people get them attested in the wrong order, and the whole chain has to be redone. The order is not negotiable. Notary (or the issuing authority), then the Ministry of External Affairs in India, then the destination country's embassy or consulate in India. Skip a link and the last stamp is worthless.

The UAE's own government portal describes the same chain for documents issued outside the country: attestation by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the issuing country, then by a UAE embassy or consulate. Some professions additionally require the degree to be attested by the UAE Ministry of Education after arrival. Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Kuwait, Oman and Bahrain each run their own embassy attestation in India, with their own forms, fees and sometimes their own Arabic translation requirements.

The document set, and what each one is for

Document	Why they want it	Watch for
Passport	Identity and travel	Six months' validity minimum, two blank pages
Degree / diploma certificate	Skill and salary band	Must be attested; Arabic translation often needed
Marksheets	Verification of the certificate	Some employers want all years
Experience letters	Salary band and role	Must match the CV dates exactly
PCC (police clearance)	Character certificate	Issued by passport office or police; valid a few months
Medical fitness certificate	GCC health screening	Only from an approved centre
Photographs	Visa and ID processing	White background, specific size per country
Marriage / birth certificates	Family visa later	Attest now if you plan to take family

Medicals: where the fake clinic operates

The UAE does its health screening in-country after arrival: HIV, hepatitis B, tuberculosis, leprosy, syphilis, and a pregnancy test for domestic workers, under the cabinet resolutions that govern residency. Several other GCC employers ask for a medical from an approved centre in India before travel. In both cases the test must be done at an approved centre — and this is where a specific fraud lives: the “medical centre” that issues a certificate without testing, or tests at a fraction of the cost and forges the rest.

A forged medical is not a victimless shortcut. If the destination country's screening finds a condition the Indian certificate denied, the worker is repatriated at his own cost, the employer claims damages, and the agent disappears. Insist on a centre you can look up, pay the centre directly, and keep the receipt.

The Arabic translation trap

Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Kuwait, Oman and Bahrain frequently require attested documents to be accompanied by a certified Arabic translation, and the translation itself sometimes needs attestation. Ask the employer's HR — in writing — exactly which documents they need, whether translation is required, and whether they will accept a digital copy for the offer stage and originals later. Getting this list once, in writing, prevents the most expensive mistake in this chapter: paying for attestation of documents nobody asked for.

CHAPTER 10

The contract, clause by clause

Everything in this book converges here. The salary, the gratuity, the ticket, the accommodation, the notice period and your ability to change employers all exist in one document, and in the Gulf that document is written in a language you may not read, signed in an office you have never seen, and then registered with a ministry you cannot call. You do not need to be a lawyer to read it. You need to know which twelve clauses carry the money.

1. Basic salary versus allowances

In the UAE, Qatar and Oman, gratuity is computed on basic salary. A contract that splits AED 5,000 into AED 2,000 basic and AED 3,000 allowances is legal and common, and it halves your end-of-service payment. In Saudi Arabia, Kuwait and Bahrain the end-of-service calculation uses the full wage including allowances, so the split matters less — but overtime, sick pay and some deductions still key off basic. Rule: know your basic as a number, not as a percentage, and know what it does to your gratuity.

The UAE Labour Law also fixes the frame around the contract: a fixed term not exceeding three years, renewable; probation of up to six months; notice between 30 and 90 days; 30 days of annual leave after a year. If your contract says 21 days of leave or a 15-day notice, it is not compliant, and a compliant employer will not mind you pointing that out.

2. The job title and the site

“Supervisor” is not a job. Neither is “staff”. The contract must name the position and the workplace, and in the UAE the employment contract is required to specify the start date, type of work, workplace, terms, duration and salary. A vague title is how people end up on a construction site when they were hired as a storekeeper, and the labour office will usually side with the written contract, not with your memory of the interview.

3. The ticket, in both directions

Ask for two sentences: who pays the initial journey, and who pays the return. The Indian specimen contract places the initial ticket on the employer, and the destination country's labour law usually places the final return ticket on the employer as well — Qatar's law, for instance, obliges the sponsoring company to bear the cost of returning the worker home within two weeks of contract expiry. Get both in the contract. Verbal assurances about tickets are the most common thing workers report losing.

4. Accommodation and food — and their value

“Accommodation provided” is worth somewhere between AED 500 and AED 3,500 a month depending on whether it is a shared labour camp or a studio, and the contract should say which. If the employer provides neither housing nor food, Qatar's minimum wage structure requires QAR 500 and QAR 300 respectively on top of the QAR 1,000 basic. Ask for photographs of the accommodation before you sign. Employers who are proud of their accommodation will send them within an hour.

5. Working hours and overtime

The regional norm is 8 hours a day and 48 a week, reduced in Ramadan, with overtime paid at a premium — typically 25% extra for daytime and 50% for night work in several Gulf laws, with the UAE providing rest-day and night differentials as well. Overtime is where blue-collar Gulf earnings are actually made and where they are most often stolen. The contract should state the overtime rate and how hours are recorded. If the site uses a biometric or gate-register system, ask that your hours be visible to you.

6. Probation, notice and the resignation clause

Probation ranges from 100 working days in Kuwait to 180 days in Saudi Arabia, and in most of the region it can be ended by either side with short notice. After probation, notice runs from 30 days in Bahrain and Oman to three months in Kuwait for monthly-paid staff, with the UAE at 30–90 days. Read the notice clause as a cost: if you leave early without serving notice, some contracts make you pay the salary for the notice period, and some employers use that clause to hold your final settlement.

7. The end-of-service clause

The contract often restates the statutory gratuity, sometimes accurately and sometimes with a creative formula. Know the statutory floor for your country from Chapter 2, and compare. A clause offering less than the law provides is void in most Gulf jurisdictions, but void clauses still get argued about at the labour office, and the argument takes months you do not have. Ask for the statutory formula to be written in.

8. The deductions clause

Gulf labour laws permit only limited deductions — typically for loans the worker agreed to, damage caused by the worker, or statutory contributions, usually capped at a percentage of wage. A contract that allows the employer to deduct “any amounts” for “any loss” is a blank cheque. Strike it out before signing, or ask for the categories to be listed.

9. The non-compete and the NOC

Many Gulf contracts restrict you from working for a competitor for a period after leaving, and most countries require the current employer's clearance or a completed minimum service before you can transfer to a new sponsor. Saudi Arabia has formalised transfer through the Qiwa platform after a year; Kuwait relaxed its one-year rule in 2026 in specified circumstances such as unpaid wages or a suspended employer file; Bahrain allows a foreign worker a second job for three months under a 2026 resolution. Understand the exit terms before you enter.

10. The third language

UAE job offers and contracts must be provided in Arabic and English, and since 2016 the employer must add a third language on the worker's request — Hindi, Malayalam, Tamil, Urdu, Bengali, Nepalese, Sinhalese, Chinese or Dari. Ask for it. A contract you cannot read is a contract you cannot check, and the third-language annex is free and legally required.

11. The registration step nobody watches

In the UAE, the employment contract must be submitted to MoHRE within 14 days of arrival or of the status change, and it is the MoHRE-registered version that the labour office will look at if there is a dispute. In Saudi Arabia the contract is documented electronically on Qiwa, where you can accept, reject or request amendments. In Qatar the contract must be registered with the Ministry of Labour. If your employer never registers you, your rights exist on paper and nowhere else. Ask for the registration confirmation and keep a screenshot.

12. The signature page

Sign nothing you have not read in a language you understand. Never sign a blank page, never sign two versions of the same contract, and never leave your passport with an agent “for processing” overnight. If a contract is presented at the airport, that is the moment to refuse — not because refusing is safe, but because a contract presented at the departure gate is a contract designed not to be read.

THE PRE-SIGNATURE CHECKLIST

- Job title and workplace are specific, not generic.
- Basic salary is stated as a number, separately from allowances.
- Both air tickets are assigned to a payer.
- Accommodation is described, not implied.
- Overtime rate and hours-recording method are stated.
- Notice period and probation length match the law.
- End-of-service formula matches the statutory floor.
- Deductions are limited to named categories.
- A third language version exists if you need it.
- You have a copy, stamped and signed, in your hand.

PART THREE

Country by country

Seven chapters, one per destination plus domestic work. Each covers the actual hiring sequence, the salary structure to insist on, the gratuity worked out on real numbers, and the three traps specific to that country. Read yours twice.

CHAPTER 11

UAE: the most documented process in the Gulf

The UAE is the easiest Gulf country to do correctly, because the process is published step by step by the government and enforced through a single ministry portal. It is also the market that contracted hardest in 2026, which makes the sequence more important, not less.

The sequence, in order

1. **Job offer.** In Arabic and English, plus a third language if you ask for one, signed electronically by the employer and sent to you abroad. It must carry an annex summarising your rights under the Labour Law.
2. **Initial work permit approval.** The employer files the signed offer with MoHRE. This approval is what allows you to enter the country — not a visit visa.
3. **Entry permit.** Valid for two months from issue. Within one month of arrival you must complete the residency procedures.
4. **Arrival and contract registration.** You and the employer sign the offer, which is then registered with MoHRE as the binding employment contract, within 14 days of arrival.
5. **Medical fitness test.** HIV, hepatitis B, TB, leprosy and syphilis screening; pregnancy test for domestic workers. Positive HIV, TB or leprosy results mean residency is refused or not renewed.
6. **Emirates ID and residence visa.** Biometrics, then the residence visa, typically valid two years for a sponsored worker.
7. **Wage Protection System.** Your salary must be paid through the WPS — a bank transfer trail the ministry can audit. Cash salaries are a warning sign.
8. **Unemployment insurance.** Register for the ILOE scheme; it is mandatory for private-sector employees, with fines for non-compliance.

> **THE VISIT-VISA TRAP, STATED PLAINLY**
>
> Working in the UAE on a visit or tourist visa is illegal, whether you are paid or not, and both worker and employer face fines. An agent who says “go on visit visa, we will convert it” is asking you to break the law in a country where your right to stay depends on your sponsor. The conversion usually does not happen, and the worker who overstayed pays the fine and the flight home.

Salary structure: negotiate the basic

A UAE package is quoted as a total. Your gratuity is computed on the basic inside it. The table below shows what the same total produces at the end of three years, purely from where the split sits.

Structure	Basic	Allowances	Gratuity / yr	After 3 yrs	After 6 yrs
Basic-heavy	AED 3,500	AED 1,500	AED 2,450	AED 7,350	AED 19,600
Balanced	AED 2,500	AED 2,500	AED 1,750	AED 5,250	AED 14,000
Allowance-heavy	AED 1,500	AED 3,500	AED 1,050	AED 3,150	AED 8,400

All three rows are the same AED 5,000 a month. The difference between the first and third row after six years is AED 11,200 — about Rs. 2.6 lakh — for identical work. The formula: 21 days of basic per year for the first five years (basic ÷ 30 × 21), then 30 days per year, capped at two years' total wage. Payment is due within 14 days of the contract ending, and resigning does not reduce it.

Employers on the mainland and in most free zones may instead join MoHRE's voluntary savings scheme, contributing 5.83% of monthly basic for staff under five years' service and 8.33% after; in the DIFC, monthly contributions to a qualifying scheme such as DEWS have been mandatory since February 2020. If your employer is

on a savings scheme, ask for the statements — the money should be visibly accumulating in your name.

Three UAE traps

- **The 14-day registration window.** If the MoHRE-registered contract never happens, your legal position is a signed offer letter and nothing else. Ask for the registration confirmation in week one and screenshot it.
- **The ILOE gap.** Unemployment insurance is mandatory and cheap, and the fine for not having it falls on the worker as well as the employer. Register yourself if HR does not, and check the certificate names you.
- **The gratuity-on-resignation myth.** Colleagues will tell you that resigning early forfeits gratuity. In the UAE it does not — Article 51 of the Labour Law computes it on service completed, and resignation does not reduce the amount. What can reduce your final settlement is unpaid notice, a loan, or a disputed deduction.

  Where to check the current rules: u.ae (the official government portal) and mohre.gov.ae. Both are updated in English and Arabic.

CHAPTER 12

Saudi Arabia: bigger award, longer leash

Saudi Arabia pays the most generous end-of-service award in the Gulf and asks the most in return: a contract documented on a government platform, a sponsor who controls your residency, and a resignation formula that takes a large bite if you leave early. The market grew through 2026 while the UAE's contracted, which is why so many Indian workers are being routed there now.

How the paperwork actually runs

1. **Contract documentation on Qiwa.** The employer creates the employment contract electronically and sends it to you; you approve, reject or request an amendment through your Qiwa Afrad account. Once both sides agree, the contract is certified by the Ministry of Human Resources and Social Development.
2. **Work visa.** The employer applies for the visa through the ministry's platform; the visa is issued against the establishment's quota and its Nitaqat band.
3. **Arrival, medical and iqama.** On arrival you complete the medical examination and the residency permit (iqama) formalities. The iqama is your identity for everything — bank account, phone, driving licence, exit and re-entry.
4. **Work permit issue or renewal.** The employer issues or renews the work permit through the ministry, paying the associated fees and levies.
5. **Wage protection.** Salaries must be paid through the approved wage protection mechanism; the employer's compliance is monitored monthly.

The award, and the resignation cut

Article 84 gives half a month's wage for each of the first five years and one full month's wage for every year after, calculated on the last wage — and unlike the UAE, the wage base includes allowances, commissions and benefits in kind. There is no cap. On a SAR 6,000 total wage, three years produces SAR 9,000; ten years produces SAR 45,000.

Then Article 85 applies the cut if you resign: nothing under two years, one third of the award between two and five years, two thirds between five and ten, and the full award at ten years and beyond. This is the clause that decides whether a Saudi contract is a three-year plan or a ten-year plan, and it should be the first thing you compute before signing.

Service at resignation	Share of award you keep	On SAR 6,000 wage
Under 2 years	Nothing	SAR 0
2 to 5 years	One third	3 yrs: SAR 3,000
5 to 10 years	Two thirds	7 yrs: SAR 21,000
10 years and above	Full	10 yrs: SAR 45,000

The award is due within one week of the end of employment, or two weeks if the employee ended the contract. If the employer terminates without a lawful cause, the full award applies and additional compensation may be owed — which is why the paper trail on any dismissal matters.

Three Saudi traps

- **Probation is long.** Up to 180 days in total, and it must be written into the contract. A six-month probation on a two-year contract means a quarter of your stay can be ended with little notice.
- **The transfer rule is a year.** Changing employers normally requires one year of service and a documented transfer through Qiwa. If your employer will not release you, the labour office is the route, and it takes time.

- **The wage figure online is not your wage.** Saudi Arabia does not set a minimum wage for expatriate workers. The salary thresholds you see quoted in “minimum wage in Saudi Arabia” articles belong to Saudization accounting for Saudi nationals, not to a floor for you.

  The residence law changed in 2024: Decree-Law No. 114 of 2024 replaced the 1959 foreigners' residence law, so older guides describing iqama and exit rules are out of date. Check hrsd.gov.sa and the Qiwa platform for the current process.

CHAPTER 13

Qatar: the only real minimum wage in the Gulf

Qatar reformed faster than any other Gulf state after 2017: a non-discriminatory minimum wage, the abolition of the exit permit, and a wage protection system that employers cannot route around. It is also the country where the most widely repeated fact about it — “the minimum wage is QAR 1,800” — is slightly wrong.

The minimum wage is three numbers, not one

Since the 2020 reform, Qatar's minimum wage is QAR 1,000 as basic pay, plus QAR 500 for accommodation and QAR 300 for food where the employer does not provide those in kind. If your employer provides housing and food, you receive the QAR 1,000 basic plus whatever the contract adds. If they provide neither, the floor is QAR 1,800 in total. Contracts that pay “QAR 1,800 all-inclusive” while also deducting rent are not compliant, and that is worth knowing before you sign.

QAR 1,000
BASIC MINIMUM
Applies to all workers, all sectors, all nationalities

QAR 500
HOUSING ALLOWANCE
Owed if the employer does not provide accommodation

QAR 300
FOOD ALLOWANCE
Owed if the employer does not provide food

The sequence

1. **Offer and contract.** The employer issues a contract; it must be registered with the Ministry of Labour, and the registered version is the one that counts.
2. **Qatar Visa Center screening.** Most work visas go through biometrics and medical screening at a Qatar Visa Center before departure — a genuine step, not an agent's invention. Do not pay an agent for a “QVC appointment” that you can book.
3. **Arrival, medical and residence permit.** In-country medical, fingerprinting and the residence permit, sponsored by the employer.
4. **Wage Protection System.** Wages must be paid into a Qatari bank account through the WPS. Cash payment is a compliance failure, not a convenience.

Gratuity and the exit

Article 54 of Law No. 14 of 2004 gives at least three weeks' wage for each year of service, on the last basic wage, pro rata for part years. On a QAR 2,000 basic, that is QAR 1,400 a year — QAR 4,200 after three years. Payment is due with the other final dues by the end of the working day after the contract ends, or within seven days if the worker ended it. The sponsoring company must also bear the cost of the return ticket within two weeks of contract expiry.

The exit permit was abolished in 2020: you no longer need your employer's permission to leave the country. Changing jobs still requires notice under the contract — one month in the first two years, two months after — and the labour law was amended again by Law No. 9 of 2026, so confirm the current notice and transfer terms with the Ministry of Labour before you plan a move.

QATAR'S QUIET ADVANTAGE

Because the minimum wage is statutory and non-discriminatory, a low offer in Qatar is easier to challenge than anywhere else in the region: the number exists, it is published, and the labour ministry enforces it through the WPS. Keep your payslips. They are the evidence.

CHAPTER 14

Kuwait: the KD 75 floor and the transfer reform

Kuwait runs the most generous statutory leave and notice in the region and the lowest minimum wage. It hires expatriates heavily through contractors and domestic work, and its 2026 reform to transfer rules is the most worker-friendly change in the Gulf this year.

Item	Kuwait rule
Main law	Private Sector Labour Law No. 6 of 2010, as amended
Probation	Up to 100 working days, once per employer
Notice	At least three months for monthly-paid staff
Annual leave	At least 30 working days
Minimum wage	KD 75 a month in the private sector
End of service	15 days' wage per year for the first five years, one month's wage per year after, capped at one and a half years' pay
Wage base	Wage including periodic allowances
Resignation	Reduced share of the indemnity until ten years of service
Transfer	Normally after one year; relaxed in 2026 in listed circumstances

The 2026 transfer reform matters more than it sounds. Until this year a foreign worker could change employers only after a year, regardless of how the employer behaved. The relaxation allows a transfer before the year is complete where the employer has failed to pay salary, failed to complete the work or residence permit steps, behaved in a way that lets the worker terminate without notice, had its company file suspended or restricted, or filed a malicious or incorrect absconding report. Every one of those is a situation Indian workers report. If you are in one of them, the route now exists — and it runs through the Public Authority for Manpower, not through an agent.

The indemnity, worked: on a KD 300 wage including allowances, three years produces KD 450 (15 days a year at KD 10 a day). Ten years produces KD 3,150 — but only if you reach ten years, because the resignation cut applies until then. Kuwait is a country where the contract term, not the salary, decides the payout.

Check the current position at the Public Authority for Manpower before relying on any figure here; Kuwait's wage and permit rules have moved several times since 2024.

CHAPTER 15

Oman: the 2027 deadline that changes your payout

Oman is the only Gulf country where the end-of-service system is visibly mid-transition, and anyone signing an Omani contract in 2027 is signing into the transition. That single fact is worth more than the rest of this chapter.

Item	Oman rule
Main law	Labour Law, Royal Decree 53 of 2023 (replaced the 2003 law)
Probation	Up to 3 months for monthly-paid staff, 2 months otherwise
Notice	30 days
Annual leave	At least 30 days
End of service	At least one basic wage per year of service, pro rata, on the last basic wage (Article 61)
Changing system	A 9% employer-funded savings system is due to replace the gratuity no later than 19 July 2027
Nationalisation	Omanisation percentages set by ministerial decision; some roles reserved for Omani nationals

On a basic wage of OMR 300, three years produces OMR 900 today. Under the savings system the employer will contribute 9% of wage monthly into a fund in your name, which is roughly OMR 324 a year on the same wage — comparable in value but completely different in nature, because the money is yours as it accrues instead of being a promise you collect at the end. Royal Decree 60 of 2025 lets the Social Protection Fund choose the start date, with 19 July 2027 the latest possible.

Practical advice for an Omani offer in 2027: ask, in writing, whether you are covered by the Article 61 gratuity or the savings system, and get the answer in the contract. If the answer is the savings system, ask for the fund name and your registration number. If the employer does not know, that is itself information.

CHAPTER 16

Bahrain: your gratuity is already being paid

Bahrain did something no other Gulf state has done: since 1 March 2024 the employer pays for expatriate end-of-service money monthly into the Social Insurance Organisation, at 4.2% of wage for the first three years and 8.4% after. The SIO pays you when service ends. Your gratuity is no longer a promise held by your employer; it is a fund with your name on it — if the contributions were actually made.

Item	Bahrain rule
Main law	Labour Law for the Private Sector, Law No. 36 of 2012, as amended
Probation	Up to 3 months; up to 6 for occupations named by the Minister
Notice	30 days
Annual leave	At least 30 days after a year's service
Minimum wage	None set for the private sector
End of service	Funded monthly through the SIO; award formula is half a month's wage per year for the first three years, a month per year after, capped at contributions paid
Service before March 2024	Settled by the employer under Article 116 on the same formula
Second job	A foreign worker may work for a second employer for three months under a 2026 LMRA resolution

The contribution rate tells you what to check. At 4.2% of a BHD 400 wage the employer pays about BHD 16.80 a month, roughly BHD 200 a year — against an award formula of half a month's wage per year (BHD 200) for the first three years. The two are designed to match, which is why the payout is capped at the contributions. If the employer has not been contributing, the cap collapses and your award with it. Ask the LMRA for the contribution record, or check through the SIO.

Bahrain also runs the region's most flexible permit system, and the 2026 second-employer resolution (LMRA Resolution No. 2 of 2026, effective 25 September 2026) allows a foreign worker to take a second job for three months. For someone whose first employer has slowed down, that is a bridge that did not exist a year ago.

CHAPTER 17

Domestic work: the route with the fewest protections

Domestic work — housemaid, nanny, cook, driver, caregiver — is the largest single category of Gulf employment for Indian women and the one with the weakest legal safety net. It is also where most of the trafficking cases reported by Indian missions begin. If you or someone in your family is considering it, this chapter is not optional.

Three structural facts make it different from every other job in this book. First, domestic workers are usually excluded from the general labour law and covered by a separate domestic workers law, with a separate dispute mechanism. Second, the workplace is somebody's home, so there is no site register, no HR department and often no witness. Third, several social insurance and unemployment schemes explicitly exclude domestic workers — the UAE's ILOE scheme, for instance, does not cover them.

The Indian rules that apply to you

- Emigration clearance is required if your passport is ECR, and the employment agreement must be attested by the Indian embassy in the destination country for unskilled workers and women emigrants.
- Women below 30 years are not granted emigration clearance for work in ECR countries under the current guidelines. There is no agent who can lawfully change that.
- PBBY insurance is mandatory for ECR clearance and is the only financial protection most domestic workers will ever hold.
- The recruiting agent must be registered, and the service charge is subject to the same Rs. 30,000 plus GST ceiling.

What the contract must say

Before signing, insist that the contract states the monthly salary and the currency, whether food and accommodation are provided, the working hours and the weekly rest day, the annual leave and the return ticket, the notice period on both sides, and the mobile phone and communication policy. That last clause sounds trivial and is not: confiscated phones are how isolation begins, and a contract that guarantees you a phone and a SIM in your own name is a real protection.

THE FIVE SENTENCES THAT SHOULD STOP YOU

- “The salary will be told after you arrive.”
- “You will get the contract at the airport.”
- “Your passport stays with the agency for safekeeping.”
- “There is no need for embassy attestation, this is a family visa.”
- “You can convert the visit visa once you are there.”

If any of those five is said to you, stop. Call the OWRC helpline on 1800-11-3090 and ask them to confirm what is being proposed. The call is free, it is answered in eleven languages, and it takes ten minutes — which is less time than a single day of the process that follows if you say yes.

PART FOUR

Fraud, and what to do when it has already happened

Three chapters: the eleven scams in the order they arrive, the rescue sequence if you are already stuck, and the letters you will need to write — drafted, so you only have to fill in the blanks.

CHAPTER 18

Eleven scams, in the order they reach you

Fraud on Gulf job seekers is not random. It follows a sequence that matches the stages of the process, because each stage offers a different thing to steal: first your hope, then your documents, then your money, then your freedom of movement. Knowing the order is most of the defence.

1. The offer letter that was never sent

A WhatsApp message with a company logo, a salary, and a PDF “offer letter” with a font that does not match the letterhead. The tell: the domain in the email address does not match the company's website, and the letter has no employee reference number. What to do: look the company up independently — not through the link you were sent — find its official email on its own website, and ask HR to confirm the offer. MEA's own guidance on verifying an offer letter is exactly this: contact the company directly.

2. The unregistered agent with a registered agent's letterhead

The office shows you another agency's licence. The tell: the registration number on the wall does not belong to the entity issuing your receipt. What to do: search the number on eMigrate and compare the licensed name to the name on the invoice. If they differ, walk.

3. The fee that grows

Rs. 25,000 to start, then a visa charge, then a medical charge, then a ticket deposit, each one small enough to feel foolish to refuse after the last. The tell: no single invoice, ever, and a new charge every week. What to do: demand one itemised GST invoice with the agent's registration number before paying anything else.

4. The visit visa sold as a work visa

“Go on a visit visa, we will convert it in a week.” The tell: your visa says visit or tourist. What to do: refuse. Working on a visit visa is illegal in the UAE and most of the region, and the conversion is the part that does not happen.

5. The salary bait

The offer says Rs. 65,000. The contract you sign at the airport says Rs. 28,000. The tell: the contract is presented at the last moment, in a language you cannot read, with no time to read it. What to do: refuse to board. A contract you did not read is not a contract you agreed to.

6. The forged attestation

A stamp that looks like the MEA's, applied in an office in your own district within an hour. The tell: real attestation has a verifiable reference and takes days, not hours. What to do: verify the attestation with the embassy whose stamp it claims to be, or refuse.

7. The fake medical

A certificate issued without a blood sample. The tell: no lab receipt, no centre you can find on a map. What to do: pay the approved centre directly and keep the receipt.

8. The sub-agent chain

Your passport moves through three hands before it reaches the licensed agent. The tell: nobody can tell you where your passport is right now. What to do: never surrender your passport for more than a few hours, and never without a written receipt naming the holder and the purpose.

9. The free visa, free ticket, salary-deduction arrangement

“No cost to you — we deduct it from salary over two years.” The tell: the deduction is not in the contract, or it is in a side letter you signed separately. What to do: assume the deduction will be larger and longer than described, and treat any side letter as part of the contract.

10. The absconding report

After you complain about unpaid wages, the employer files an absconding report, which converts you from a worker with a grievance into a person in violation of residency rules. The tell: your complaint is followed by a threat instead of a payslip. What to do: go to the labour office and your embassy the same week — the sequence in Chapter 19 exists for this exact situation, and Kuwait's 2026 reform explicitly covers malicious absconding reports.

11. The return-ticket trap

Your contract ends, the employer will not pay the return ticket, and your residency expires in nine days. The tell: no ticket clause in the contract, and an employer who stops answering in the last month. What to do: start the exit paperwork 60 days before contract end, not 10, and put the ticket demand in writing while you are still employed.

THE ONE QUESTION THAT FILTERS MOST OF THEM

“Which ministry will register this contract, and what is the registration number?” In the UAE it is MoHRE, in Saudi Arabia it is Qiwa, in Qatar the Ministry of Labour, in Kuwait PAM, in Oman the Ministry of Labour, in Bahrain the LMRA. An operator who works legally answers in one sentence. An operator who does not changes the subject.

CHAPTER 19

If you are already stuck: the rescue sequence

This chapter assumes the worst has happened in some form: unpaid wages, a withheld passport, a job that is not the job, an absconding report, or a relative who has stopped answering the phone. Do these in this order. The order matters more than the speed.

Step 1 — Get the facts onto paper, today

Write down, in one document: your full name, passport number, visa type and expiry, employer's registered name and address, sponsor's name, date of arrival, monthly salary promised and received, the date of the first unpaid salary, and the names and phone numbers of two colleagues. Photograph your passport, visa page, labour card or Emirates ID, contract and any payslips. Send the photographs to your own email and to a family member in India. Whatever happens next, you will need this file, and reconstructing it later is much harder than creating it now.

Step 2 — Call the OWRC helpline from wherever you are

The Overseas Workers Resource Centre runs round the clock, 365 days a year, on 1800-11-3090 from India (and +91-124-2341002 from abroad), in eleven languages including Hindi, Malayalam, Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Bengali, Punjabi, Gujarati, Marathi and Odia. It is an Indian government service and it is free. Ask them to log your case and tell you which office to approach next. The log matters: it creates a record with a date.

Step 3 — Register on MADAD and at the embassy

MADAD is the MEA's grievance portal for Indians abroad; a registered grievance gets a case number and follows you between offices. In parallel, contact the Indian embassy or consulate in your country and ask for the labour wing — every Gulf mission has a labour attaché whose job is exactly this. Take your document file. Ask for a written acknowledgement of your complaint, even a stamp on a copy.

Step 4 — File with the local labour office, not the police

In the UAE that is MoHRE; in Saudi Arabia the Ministry of Human Resources; in Qatar the Ministry of Labour; in Kuwait the Public Authority for Manpower; in Oman the Ministry of Labour; in Bahrain the LMRA. Wage complaints are administrative in the first instance and usually free. Go in person with your file, and take a colleague as a witness if you can. Do not sign anything you do not understand, including a settlement you are told is “just a formality”.

Step 5 — Protect your status before you protect your claim

If your residency is tied to an employer who is not paying you, the sequence that protects you is: labour complaint first, then the transfer or exit, then the money. Leaving the country before the complaint is filed usually ends the claim; staying without status creates a fine. This is the point at which a labour attaché's advice is worth more than any agent's, and it is free.

Step 6 — If your passport is held

Withholding a worker's passport is unlawful across the Gulf, and it is one of the grievances the OWRC explicitly handles. Report it to the embassy and the labour office in writing. If the passport is lost or destroyed, the embassy can issue an emergency certificate to travel, but only after police and immigration formalities — which is why you report early, not on the day of the flight.

Step 7 — If it is an emergency or a death

For a medical emergency, the embassy's 24-hour number and the Indian Community Welfare Fund are the two mechanisms that exist. For a death, the mission handles repatriation of remains and the family should contact the embassy directly and immediately, quoting the passport number, the employer's name and the hospital's name. Do not pay an intermediary for this; it is a consular function.

WHAT NOT TO DO

- Do not pay a second agent to “fix” a problem the first agent created — this is the most common way a bad situation becomes unrecoverable.
- Do not sign a resignation under pressure without a settlement in writing.
- Do not overstay while waiting for a resolution; the fine accrues against you, not the employer.
- Do not let anyone hold your original documents as security for a promise.

CHAPTER 20

The five letters you may need

Written complaints work in the Gulf for a simple reason: they create a date, and every labour process in the region runs on dates. Keep them short, factual and free of anger. Send by email where possible and keep the sent copy. Replace the bracketed text and delete nothing else.

1. TO THE EMPLOYER — UNPAID SALARY

```
Subject: Non-payment of salary for [month/year] - [Your Name] - Passport [number]

Dear [HR Manager / Mr/Ms Name],

I am employed as [job title] at [workplace] under contract dated [date], employee
number [number]. My monthly salary is [amount and currency], payable on [day].

My salary for [month] has not been credited to my bank account as of [date]. This is
the [first/second] month of delay. Under [the applicable labour law] wages are due
on the agreed date and must be paid through the wage protection system.

I request payment of [amount] within seven days, and a written explanation of the
delay. If payment is not received I will file a complaint with [MoHRE / the Ministry
of Human Resources / the Ministry of Labour] and inform the Indian Embassy.

Yours sincerely,
[Name] [Phone] [Email]
```

2. TO THE INDIAN EMBASSY — LABOUR WING

```
Subject: Request for assistance - Indian worker, unpaid wages - [Your Name]

Respected Sir/Madam,

I am an Indian national, passport [number], resident in [city, country] since [date].
I am employed by [employer registered name], sponsor [name], as [job title].

Problem: [wages unpaid since DATE / passport withheld / contract substituted on arrival
/ absconding report filed after my complaint]. Total amount due: [amount].

I have attached: passport copy, visa copy, labour card/ID, employment contract,
payslips, and my written complaint to the employer dated [date].

I request the Mission's assistance in taking up this matter with the employer and the
labour authorities. My contact details are below and I can attend the Embassy any
working day.

[Name] [Phone] [Email] [Address in country]
```

3. COMPLAINT TO THE PROTECTOR OF EMIGRANTS / EMIGRATE

```
Subject: Complaint against recruiting agent [RA name], registration no. [number]

1. Complainant: [name], passport [number], address [address], phone [number].
2. Agent: [name], registration no. [number], office address [address].
3. Amount paid: [total], of which service charge [amount], on dates [dates].
4. Receipts attached: [yes/no - if no, state what you hold: bank transfer, chat,
witness].
5. What was promised: [job title, employer, country, salary].
6. What happened: [no visa issued / different employer / no job on arrival /
excess charge above Rs. 30,000 + GST].
7. Relief sought: refund of [amount] and action against the agent under the
Emigration Act, 1983.

I declare the above is true. [Name] [Date] [Signature]
```

4. TO THE FAMILY, BEFORE YOU FLY

```
MY WORK DETAILS - KEEP THIS

Name: ..... Passport: .....
Country / city: ..... Employer (registered name): .....
Sponsor name: ..... Phone: .....
Job title: ..... Salary: ..... Paid on: .....
Accommodation address: .....
Indian Embassy number: .....
OWRC helpline from abroad: +91-124-2341002
PBBY insurer and policy no.: .....
Contract start / end: ..... / .....
Two colleagues' phone numbers: .....
```

5. EXIT CHECKLIST REQUEST TO THE EMPLOYER

```
Subject: End of contract - final settlement and return ticket

My contract ends on [date]. I request, in writing:
1. Final settlement calculation including end-of-service benefit, unpaid salary,
leave encashment and any deductions with reasons.
2. Confirmation that my return air ticket to [city, India] will be provided, and
the booking details.
3. Cancellation of my work permit and residence visa on the date of departure, and
a copy of the cancellation.
4. A service certificate and experience letter.

Please confirm within seven days so that I can plan my departure.

[Name] [Date]
```

PART FIVE

Living and working there

The paperwork gets you in. These five chapters are about the part nobody prepares for: the first ninety days, the working conditions, the health system, the specific position of women workers, and three offers worked through side by side with real arithmetic.

CHAPTER 21

The first ninety days: a sequence, not a scramble

The first three months decide whether the next three years work. Almost everything that goes wrong later — unpaid wages, a contract you cannot prove, a residency that lapses — goes wrong in this window, when you are jet-lagged, grateful and reluctant to make trouble.

Week one: identity and money

1. **Get the contract registered.** In the UAE the employment contract must be submitted to MoHRE within 14 days of arrival. In Saudi Arabia the contract lives on Qiwa, where you can see and approve it. In Qatar it must be registered with the Ministry of Labour. Ask for the confirmation and photograph the screen.
2. **Complete the medical and biometrics.** The in-country medical and Emirates ID or iqama process is your employer's obligation, not a favour. Do not pay for it yourself unless the contract says you do.
3. **Open a bank account.** You need it for the Wage Protection System. Take your passport, visa, ID application receipt and employer letter. Salaries paid in cash are a compliance problem, and often a warning.
4. **Buy a local SIM in your own name.** Not a colleague's spare line. Your phone number becomes your identity for banking, government apps and emergency contact.

Week two: the things that cost money if you get them wrong

- **Photograph your accommodation on day one.** Every room, the meter, the door lock, the bathroom. If the employer later claims damages, the photographs are your defence, and after a month they are worthless as evidence.
- **Find out what your accommodation actually costs you.** Free accommodation sometimes means a deduction for utilities, or a shared room with six people. Both are legal if the contract says so; neither is legal if it appears as a surprise deduction.
- **Register for unemployment insurance in the UAE.** It is mandatory, it is cheap, and the fine for not having it applies to you as well as the employer.
- **Send the “my work details” sheet home.** Chapter 20 has the template. Two family members should be able to name your employer and your embassy without calling you.

Weeks three to six: build your file

Keep a folder — physical and in the cloud — with your contract, visa, labour card or ID, payslips, attendance records and any written communication about your salary. In a dispute, the worker with a folder wins arguments that the worker without one loses. This takes ten minutes a month and it is the highest-return habit in this book.

Also use these weeks to learn the two things nobody teaches: where the labour office is, and where your embassy is. Not because you expect trouble, but because knowing the route removes the main reason people tolerate bad employers — the belief that there is no alternative.

The first salary: check it line by line

Compare the credited amount to the contract, not to what you expected. Look for deductions you did not agree to, for a lower basic than the contract states, and for an “accommodation” or “food” deduction that the contract says is provided free. Raise the first discrepancy in writing, in the first month. A pattern established in month one is much harder to break in month nine.

THE 45-DAY CASH RULE

Assume your first salary will arrive 30–45 days after you land, whatever anyone told you. Carry enough for that period — rent share, food, transport, phone — and do not lend it out in week one to a colleague who is short. This single precaution prevents most of the borrowing at moneylender rates that traps new arrivals.

CHAPTER 22

Working there: heat, Ramadan and the six ways people get fired

Gulf work is not harder than Indian work. It is the same work in a different legal climate, with a sponsor who controls your residency and a summer that can kill a person who ignores it. Both facts deserve a chapter.

Heat is a safety issue, not a complaint

The UAE enforces an annual midday break: outdoor work is banned between roughly 12:30 and 15:00 from mid-June to mid-September, and employers must provide shade, cool drinking water and rest areas. Other Gulf states have similar summer rules. Heat stroke is the most common serious occupational injury among new arrivals, and it is almost always preventable with water, salt, shade and pacing in the first two weeks while the body adapts. If your site ignores the midday break, report it — anonymously if you must — and do not treat a supervisor's impatience as a reason to risk your life.

Ramadan changes the working day

During Ramadan, working hours are reduced across the region — the UAE Labour Law reduces the working day by two hours for all workers, and Saudi Arabia shortens the day for Muslim employees. Site timings, canteen hours and transport all shift. Two practical notes: eating, drinking or smoking in public during daylight is restricted in most Gulf states, including for non-Muslims in some; and the last week before Eid is the busiest and most impatient of the year, which is worth planning around rather than arguing with.

The six things that actually get workers fired

1. **Absconding.** Leaving the job or the accommodation without notice, or being absent without approval. It is treated as a residency violation, not a resignation, and it can bar you from re-entry.
2. **Being caught working for someone else.** A second job without a permit is a serious violation for both parties. Bahrain's 2026 three-month second-job rule is an exception, not the norm.
3. **Fighting or alcohol.** Both are fast-track dismissals across the region, and alcohol carries legal consequences beyond the job.
4. **Social media.** Posting photographs of a workplace, a site, a residence or a colleague can breach employer rules and, in some cases, local law. Assume anything you post is seen by HR.
5. **Refusing safety equipment.** A worker who removes a harness to work faster is dismissed, and the employer is fined. The equipment is not optional.
6. **Disappearing during probation.** Probation is short and the employer's patience is shorter. Two unexplained absences in a probation month is usually the end.

Notice what is not on that list: asking for your salary, refusing an unsafe task, or complaining to the labour office. Those are rights. Workers are sometimes told otherwise, and the labour office exists precisely to correct that.

Driving, transport and the daily commute

India is not on the list of countries whose driving licences can be converted directly in the UAE; most Indian licence holders must go through a driving school and the local test, which takes weeks and costs money. Until then, transport is the employer's bus, a shared van, or walking — and in summer, walking is not an option at midday. Ask at interview how you will get to the site. It is a legitimate question and the answer tells you a lot about the employer.

CHAPTER 23

Health: what is covered, what is not, and what to do at 2 a.m.

The Gulf has good hospitals and a payment system that assumes insurance. If you are insured through your employer, the care is usually excellent. If you are not — because the employer never enrolled you, or because the policy excludes you — a single admission can consume a year of savings. This chapter is about knowing which situation you are in before you need to know.

Three questions to answer in week one

1. Am I enrolled in the employer's health insurance, and what is the policy number? Ask for the card. In the UAE and Saudi Arabia, employer-provided health cover is a legal obligation, not a benefit.
2. Does the policy cover dependants, and does it cover the conditions I already have? Pre-existing conditions and dental care are the two standard exclusions.
3. Which hospital is in-network, and is there an emergency route that does not need pre-approval? Save that hospital's address in your phone tonight.

   If you are not enrolled, that is a labour complaint and a health risk at the same time. Raise it in writing in your first month. Workers who discover the gap during an emergency usually pay in cash and then argue for years.

When the emergency is not yours

Two scenarios are worth preparing for because they arrive without warning. A colleague's accident: your role is to call the ambulance, inform the supervisor and the site safety officer, and record names and times. A death in the community: the Indian mission handles repatriation of remains, and the family should contact the embassy directly with the passport number and the employer's name. PBBY, which you bought for Rs. 275, is the insurance that responds to accidental death and permanent disability — and the policy document you photographed and sent home is what makes the claim possible.

> **THE MEDICAL FILE EVERYONE SHOULD CARRY**
>
> - Insurance card and policy number.
> - Blood group, allergies and current medication, written on paper.
> - Two emergency contacts — one in the country, one in India.
> - The Indian embassy's 24-hour number.
> - Your PBBY policy number.

Mental health deserves one honest paragraph. Isolation, debt pressure, a shared room with no privacy and a job that cannot be left are a specific kind of strain, and it is common. Talking to family weekly, keeping one friendship outside work, and using the embassy's community services is not a soft suggestion — it is the difference between enduring a contract and breaking under it. If you or a colleague is in crisis, the mission and the OWRC helpline are the two numbers that answer.

CHAPTER 24

Women at work in the Gulf: the rules that matter

Women from India work across the Gulf in healthcare, education, hospitality, retail, domestic work and increasingly in engineering and finance. The legal framework is not the obstacle most people imagine; the practical arrangements — accommodation, transport and who holds your documents — are where the risk actually sits.

What the law provides

- **Equal pay for equal work** is written into the UAE Labour Law, and discrimination on the basis of gender is prohibited in employment terms.
- **Maternity leave** in the UAE runs to 60 days — 45 at full pay and 15 at half pay under the current Labour Law — with additional unpaid leave in specified cases. Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Kuwait, Oman and Bahrain each have their own maternity provisions ranging from roughly 45 days to 10 weeks; check the specific law for your country before planning a pregnancy around a contract.
- **Harassment** is a criminal matter as well as a labour one across the region. The route is a police complaint plus a labour complaint plus a call to your embassy — in that order if you are in immediate danger, and in parallel if you are not.
- **Nursing breaks** and workplace accommodation for new mothers exist in several Gulf labour laws, usually for a defined period after return to work.

What the contract must settle before you sign

1. Is the accommodation single-sex, and is it women-only? Get it in writing, and ask for photographs.
2. Is transport provided to and from the workplace? A night shift with no transport is a safety issue, not a convenience issue.
3. Who holds my passport? The answer must be: I do.
4. Is there a female supervisor or a named person to whom a complaint goes? Ask who it is.
5. What is the policy on phone use and on leaving the accommodation? Any answer that restricts movement outside working hours is a warning.

One Indian rule deserves repeating here: women below 30 years are not granted emigration clearance for work in ECR countries under the current guidelines. Any agent offering to arrange it is describing a forged clearance. The lawful routes are a passport without the ECR endorsement where you qualify, or a different destination.

> **THE SINGLE BEST PROTECTION**
>
> Two people in India who know your employer's registered name, your address abroad, your embassy's number and a fixed weekly call time. Isolation is the mechanism through which most abuse of migrant women workers succeeds, and predictable contact is the cheapest defence against it.

CHAPTER 25

Three offers, decided

The numbers below are illustrative, constructed to show how the decision works rather than to describe any real employer. Read the method, then run your own offers through it.

The three offers

	Offer A — UAE	Offer B — Saudi Arabia	Offer C — Qatar
Job	Store supervisor, Dubai	Site supervisor, Riyadh	Warehouse supervisor, Doha
Total monthly	AED 5,000	SAR 4,800	QAR 4,600
Basic	AED 2,500	SAR 2,400	QAR 2,300
Accommodation	Provided (shared)	Provided (shared)	Allowance QAR 500
Food	Not provided	Not provided	Allowance QAR 300
Ticket home	Employer, annually	Employer, every 2 years	Employer, annually
Probation	6 months	90 days	6 months
Gratuity base	Basic only	Full wage	Basic only

The three-year comparison

Line	UAE	Saudi Arabia	Qatar
Total pay over 3 years	AED 180,000	SAR 172,800	QAR 165,600
Rent paid by me	Nil (provided)	Nil (provided)	QAR 18,000
Food paid by me (est.)	AED 32,400	SAR 31,000	Nil (allowance covers)
Left in hand, 3 years	AED 147,600	SAR 141,800	QAR 136,200
End of service	AED 5,250	SAR 21,600 (if completed)	QAR 4,830
Approx. total in rupees	Rs. 35.1 lakh	Rs. 33.6 lakh	Rs. 27.5 lakh

At Rs. 23 to the dirham, Rs. 30 to the riyal and Rs. 23 to the Qatari riyal, the three offers land within a few lakh of each other over three years — and the ranking changes if the worker resigns early. Saudi Arabia's award is the largest, but a resignation between two and five years cuts it to one third: SAR 7,200 instead of SAR 21,600. Qatar's allowances look generous until you notice the basic, and therefore the gratuity, is the lowest of the three.

The decision rule that emerges: compare total rupees over the exact period you intend to stay, not the monthly salary; treat the gratuity as contingent on how you leave; and weight the ticket and accommodation clauses as money, because they are.

WORKSHEET 8 — THREE OFFERS, MY NUMBERS

Fill one column per offer, using the period you actually intend to stay.

Total monthly pay, in local currency
Basic salary (for gratuity)
Rent and utilities I pay
Food I pay
Ticket — who pays, how often
Total in rupees over my intended stay
End of service if I leave after that period
The one clause that worries me

PART SIX

Money, family and the way back

Four chapters on the half of the job nobody plans: where the salary goes, what the tax office at home expects, how a family joins you, and how to leave on your own terms instead of the employer's.

CHAPTER 26

Remittance: the account decides the cost

A Gulf salary is earned in a currency that converts well and spent in one that does not. The mechanics of moving it home — which account, which channel, how often — are worth more over five years than most salary negotiations, because they are pure leakage: no extra work, just less loss.

The three accounts

Account	What it is for	Tax in India	Repatriation
NRE	Parking foreign earnings in rupees; day-to-day transfers home	Interest tax-free while you are non-resident	Fully repatriable
NRO	Money earned in India — rent, dividends, sale proceeds	Interest taxable, TDS applies	Limited, with documentation
FCNR (B)	Foreign-currency term deposit held in India	Interest tax-free while non-resident	Fully repatriable, in that currency

Open the NRE account in your first month, not your first year. It needs your passport, visa, employment letter and local address, and it is far easier to open while the paperwork is fresh. Salaries parked in a local account earning nothing are the most common quiet loss in the Gulf.

The rules that govern the transfer

- **LRS.** Residents may remit up to USD 250,000 per financial year under the Liberalised Remittance Scheme. For an NRI sending money home, the relevant rules are different — but if you are a resident sending money out (for a dependent, a property or an investment), LRS is the ceiling and the declaration.
- **TCS.** Tax collected at source applies to certain outward remittances above a threshold, at rates that have been revised more than once — the threshold for most remittances was raised to Rs. 10 lakh per financial year from April 2025, with a lower rate for education and medical purposes. TCS is not a tax you lose; it is credited against your liability. Confirm the current rate with your bank before a large transfer.
- **Purpose codes.** Every transfer carries a purpose code. “Family maintenance” is not the same as “property purchase”, and a wrong code creates a reconciliation problem later. Ask the bank which code they are using and keep the advice slip.

How to choose a channel in twenty minutes

1. Take a round number — say Rs. 50,000 — and get the final rupee amount that lands in the beneficiary account, not the advertised rate.
2. Do this for four channels: your bank's app, a large exchange house, a specialist remittance app, and a second bank. The spread is usually 0.5% to 2%, and it is invisible if you only compare the headline rate.
3. Multiply the gap by twelve. A 1% difference on Rs. 50,000 a month is Rs. 6,000 a year — a month's food.
4. Check the receiving bank's inward-remittance charge, which is often the hidden half of the cost.
5. Set a fixed date each month and automate it. Consistency beats optimisation.

> **THE DISCIPLINE THAT BEATS THE EXCHANGE RATE**
>
> A fixed transfer on the 3rd of every month, before discretionary spending, will out-save a perfect exchange rate on irregular transfers. Decide the amount once, at the start of the year, and treat the remainder as genuinely yours to spend.

CHAPTER 27

Tax: the 182-day line and what it does to your salary

The Gulf salary is famous for being tax-free, and for Indian workers the useful version of that claim is narrower: a salary earned and received outside India, by a person who is not a resident of India, is generally not taxable in India. The condition — residence — is decided by days, and the days are decided by you.

Residence, in one page

Under Section 6 of the Income-tax Act, you are a resident of India for a financial year if you are in India for 182 days or more in that year, or for 60 days or more in that year and 365 days or more in the four preceding years. A separate rule covers deemed residence for Indian citizens with Indian income above the prescribed threshold who are not taxed anywhere else. Being resident does not automatically make your foreign salary taxable — but it starts an argument you do not want to have from 3,000 km away.

Days in India in the financial year	Status	Effect on Gulf salary
Under 182	Non-resident (subject to the other tests)	Generally not taxable in India
182 or more	Resident	Residency rules apply; RNOR may still exempt foreign income
Resident but RNOR	Resident Not Ordinarily Resident	Foreign income not received in India is generally outside the tax net
Resident and ROR	Resident and Ordinarily Resident	Global income taxable in India

RNOR status usually applies if you have been non-resident in nine of the ten preceding years, or in India for 729 days or fewer in the seven preceding years. This is why the first two years after returning are the years to plan carefully: you often have RNOR status, and foreign income that would later be taxable can be brought in during that window. That planning is worth a conversation with a chartered accountant before you return, not after.

What else follows you

- **Double taxation.** India has tax treaties with the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Kuwait, Oman and Bahrain. Most Gulf states do not levy personal income tax, so the treaty mostly matters for confirming that the income is not taxed twice — keep your salary certificate and contract, which is what a assessing officer will ask for.
- **Indian income stays Indian.** Rent from a flat in India, interest on an NRO account, capital gains on an Indian property or fund — all taxable in India regardless of where you live. TDS is deducted at source; file a return if you want the refund.
- **NRE interest is tax-free while you are non-resident.** The moment you become resident again, that interest becomes taxable. The account does not change; your status does.
- **PPF.** An existing PPF account can generally be continued to maturity, but a new one is not available to a non-resident. Do not close an old one casually; the maturity date is valuable.
- **EPF.** If you left an Indian job, your EPF can stay invested or be withdrawn under the applicable rules; leaving it untouched for years is usually the better default unless you need the money.

> **THE TWO DOCUMENTS TO KEEP FOR SEVEN YEARS**
>
> Your employment contract and your annual salary certificate, for every year you work abroad. If the tax office ever asks how a remittance was funded, those two documents answer the question in one page. Photograph them and keep them in the cloud, not in a suitcase.

CHAPTER 28

Taking the family: what it really costs

Family sponsorship is the single biggest upgrade in quality of life available to a Gulf worker, and the single biggest destroyer of the savings rate. Both are true, and the decision should be made with a spreadsheet rather than with guilt.

The three questions, in order

1. **Does your salary qualify?** Every GCC state sets a minimum income for sponsoring dependants, and the thresholds differ. In the UAE the commonly applied rule has been AED 4,000 a month, or AED 3,000 plus employer-provided accommodation — verify with the residency authority before you plan, because the figure is revised. Saudi Arabia and Qatar apply their own thresholds and their own document requirements.
2. **What does the package cost?** Add visa fees, medical insurance for each dependent, school fees, and the housing upgrade from a shared room to a family flat. In most Gulf cities the school fee alone is the largest single line, and it is charged annually in advance.
3. **Can your spouse work?** The UAE and Qatar allow dependants to take up employment with a permit; Saudi Arabia generally does not allow dependants to work. If your savings model assumes a second income, check the rule before you move.

Cost line	What to expect	How to plan
Dependant visa and medical	Per person, per renewal cycle	Budget annually, not monthly
Health insurance	Mandatory in the UAE; employer covers the employee, dependants usually paid by you	Get three quotes before deciding
School fees	The largest recurring line; annual, in advance	Ask the school for the full fee schedule including transport
Housing upgrade	Shared room to one-bedroom flat	The single biggest monthly jump
Flights home	Annual, per person	Book early; August and December cost most

A workable rule: do not sponsor a family until your savings rate with them in the country is still at least 20% of net salary, and you hold three months of expenses in cash. Below that, you are financing a lifestyle with a gratuity you have not earned yet.

One more thing worth saying plainly: many families do better with the split arrangement — the worker abroad, the family at home, with two visits a year — than with an unhappy household in a city where the second adult has no work permit, no driving licence and no community. That is a personal decision, not a financial one, but it should be made with the numbers in front of both adults.

CHAPTER 29

The exit plan: leaving on your own terms

Almost nobody plans the exit, which is why most exits are decided by a contract expiry, a layoff or a family emergency. The people who do best out of the Gulf are the ones who decided, before leaving India, what year they would come back and what the money was for.

The five-year arithmetic

Take the Chapter 4 model: AED 950 left in hand monthly, AED 11,400 a year, plus gratuity of AED 1,750 a year on a AED 2,500 basic. Over five years that is roughly AED 65,750 — about Rs. 15 lakh at Rs. 23 to the dirham — before any salary increase. Add a normal 5% annual raise and the same person finishes five years closer to Rs. 18–20 lakh. That is a house deposit in a tier-2 city, a funded education, or a small business — and it is also exactly the amount that disappears when the money arrives with no destination.

The six mistakes that erase five years

- **Building the house in year two.** The house consumes the savings, sits empty, and absorbs the remittances for a decade. Build in the last two years of the plan, not the first two.
- **Lifestyle creep in year three.** The first raise goes to a better flat and a bigger car loan. The savings rate, not the salary, is what compounds.
- **Lending to relatives without documents.** The most common reason a five-year plan returns nothing. Lend only what you can afford to lose, in writing.
- **Gold bought as savings.** Gold is a store of value with a making charge and a resale discount. It is not a plan.
- **No emergency fund.** Three months of expenses in cash prevents the one event that forces a loan at moneylender rates.
- **Treating gratuity as retirement.** For most workers the gratuity is one to three months of salary. It is a bonus, not a pension.

The return decision

Come back when the money has a destination, when your skills have a market in India, and when your documents are in order. That last point is the most neglected: before you leave, collect your experience certificate, your end-of-service settlement, your cancellation of sponsorship, your bank statements and your PBBY record. Getting these after you have left the country is slow, expensive and sometimes impossible. Chapter 20's fifth letter is the request that gets them.

And if you are returning to a job, start looking four months before the flight, not four weeks. Gulf experience is valued in India in healthcare, logistics, construction management, hospitality, sales and finance — and it is discounted everywhere else unless you can show a specific skill, a certification or a portfolio. The interview question is always the same: what did you do there that you could not have done here? Have an answer before you land.

WORKSHEET 3 — THE EXIT PLAN

Fill this in your first month abroad, and revisit it every year.

Year I intend to return

Amount I need before I return

What the money is for (one sentence)

Monthly savings target to get there

Three months' emergency fund held where

Documents I must collect before leaving

What I will do in month one after returning

PART SEVEN

The toolkit

A 30-day plan, the printable worksheets in one place, the official links to check everything in this book, and the questions people actually ask.

CHAPTER 30

The 30-day plan

Thirty days, in the order that keeps you out of trouble. If you are further along, start at the week that matches where you are.

Days 1–5: verify before you engage

1. Check your passport for the ECR endorsement and note the expiry.
2. List every agent who has contacted you, with the registration number each one claims.
3. Search each number on eMigrate and record the licensed name and status.
4. Find the employer's own website and email domain; compare with the offer letter.
5. Write down the salary, the job title and the country in one line, and keep it.

Days 6–12: documents

1. Decide the attestation chain for your destination and get a written quote from two agencies.
2. Apply for the PCC if the employer needs it.
3. Book a medical at an approved centre — you choose the centre, not the agent.
4. Photograph every document, front and back, and store it in the cloud.
5. Ask HR in writing for the exact document list, including translation requirements.

Days 13–20: money and the contract

1. Read the contract against the twelve clauses in Chapter 10, with a pen.
2. Ask for the basic salary to be stated as a number, and negotiate the split if you can.
3. Confirm both air tickets in writing.
4. Buy PBBY and register the policy with your family.
5. Complete Worksheet 1 (cost to go) and Worksheet 2 (three-year savings).
6. If you are borrowing, confirm the repayment is under a fifth of net salary.

Days 21–27: registration and clearance

1. Complete your eMigrate registration if you are going directly through an employer.
2. Confirm the Protector of Emigrants office where the clearance will be filed.
3. Get the PBBY policy number in writing before you pay for the ticket.
4. Check the visa type on the sticker — work visa, not visit.
5. Open the NRE account process with your bank so it starts on arrival.

Days 28–30: leave cleanly

1. Give your family the completed “My work details” sheet from Chapter 20.
2. Share your flight details and the embassy number with two people.
3. Carry: passport, visa, contract copy, PBBY policy, medical, photographs, and Rs. 15,000 equivalent in cash for the first month.
4. Do not carry originals of documents the employer has not asked to see.
5. Photograph your luggage and the contract before boarding.

CHAPTER 31

The printable worksheets

Four sheets, designed to be printed and filled by hand. If you only do one, do the contract red-flag sheet — it is the one that stops the expensive mistakes.

WORKSHEET 4 — CONTRACT RED-FLAG SHEET

Tick every line you can confirm from the contract itself, not from what you were told.

- [ ] Job title and workplace are named specifically
- [ ] Basic salary stated as a number; allowances stated separately
- [ ] Overtime rate stated, and hours recorded by a system I can see
- [ ] Accommodation described (type, sharing, utilities)
- [ ] Food provided or allowance stated
- [ ] Initial air ticket payer named
- [ ] Return air ticket payer named
- [ ] Probation length stated and matches the law
- [ ] Notice period stated and matches the law
- [ ] End-of-service formula stated and matches the statutory floor
- [ ] Deductions limited to named categories
- [ ] Contract is in a language I can read
- [ ] I hold a signed, stamped copy

WORKSHEET 5 — PRE-DEPARTURE DOCUMENT CHECKLIST

One copy in your bag, one photograph in the cloud.

- [ ] Passport (6+ months validity, 2 blank pages)
- [ ] Work visa (not visit/tourist)
- [ ] Employment contract, signed and stamped
- [ ] PBBY policy document and number
- [ ] Medical certificate from an approved centre
- [ ] Attested degree/diploma
- [ ] PCC if required
- [ ] Photographs (12, white background)
- [ ] Employer's address and phone, written down
- [ ] Indian embassy number in destination
- [ ] OWRC number +91-124-2341002
- [ ] First-month cash and a working phone

WORKSHEET 6 — FIRST-WEEK ABROAD

Do these seven things before your first salary, not after.

Contract registered with the labour ministry (ask for the confirmation)

Copy of my contract in my own hand

Local SIM in my own name

Bank account opened; salary routed through the wage protection system

Unemployment insurance registered (UAE)

Accommodation inspected and photographed

Embassy registration / MADAD account created

WORKSHEET 7 — MONTHLY MONEY SHEET

Fill on the 1st, transfer on the 3rd, review on the 30th.

Salary credited (amount and date)

Rent paid

Food, transport, phone

Sent home (amount and channel)

Loan repayment

Saved this month

Running total of savings

Months to my exit target

CHAPTER 32

Where to check everything, officially

Every fact in this book has a page behind it. These are the pages. Bookmark them on your phone before you leave India; several are hard to reach from a labour camp network and much easier to reach now.

What you need to check	Where
Recruiting agent licence, blacklist, your registration, complaints	emigrate.gov.in (MEA eMigrate)
Emigration clearance rules, ECR list, PBBY	mea.gov.in
Overseas Workers Resource Centre helpline	1800-11-3090 (India), +91-124-2341002 (abroad)
Grievance registration for Indians abroad	MADAD portal, madad.gov.in
UAE: offer, contract, work permit, gratuity, ILOE, disputes	u.ae and mohre.gov.ae
Saudi Arabia: contract documentation, work permit, Qiwa	hrsd.gov.sa and qiwa.sa
Qatar: contract registration, minimum wage, WPS	hukoomi.gov.qa and the Ministry of Labour
Kuwait: work permits, transfers, complaints	Public Authority for Manpower (PAM)
Oman: labour law, permits, WPS	mol.gov.om
Bahrain: permits, SIO contributions, disputes	lmra.bh
Indian passport, PCC, ECNR	passportindia.gov.in
Remittance limits, LRS, TCS	rbi.org.in and your bank's remittance desk
Income tax residence and returns	incometax.gov.in

THE RULE FOR ANYTHING THAT HAS A NUMBER IN IT

If a fee, a salary threshold or a fine matters to your decision, check it on the official page on the day you decide. Rules in the Gulf change by decree and the change is often announced on a Sunday and effective on a Monday.

CHAPTER 33

Questions people actually ask

Do I need an agent at all?

No. You can be recruited directly by a foreign employer and register yourself on eMigrate for clearance. Direct recruitment is common for nurses, engineers, IT staff and technicians. Agents are useful for volume hiring where the employer will not deal with individuals, but they are never compulsory.

Is the Rs. 30,000 cap the total I should pay?

No. It caps the agent's service charge, plus GST. Passport, medical, attestation, insurance and your ticket are separate and mostly real costs. If your agent's charge alone exceeds the cap, that is the complaint.

Can I go on a visit visa and find a job there?

It is illegal to work on a visit or tourist visa in the UAE, and similar restrictions apply across the region. Employers who hire on visit visas are the ones most likely to withhold wages, because they already hold your status over you.

My agent says ECR clearance is not needed because the visa is a work visa. Is he right?

No. Clearance depends on the stamp in your passport and the destination country, not on the visa type. An ECR passport holder going to an ECR country for employment needs clearance, full stop.

What is the minimum salary in Dubai?

There is no statutory minimum wage for the UAE private sector. Your salary is whatever the registered contract says. Anyone quoting a “minimum wage in Dubai” is usually quoting a market average, not a law.

Is Qatar's minimum wage QAR 1,800?

Not as a single number. It is QAR 1,000 basic, plus QAR 500 for housing and QAR 300 for food where the employer does not provide them in kind. If accommodation and food are provided, the basic is QAR 1,000.

How much gratuity will I get after three years?

UAE: 21 days of basic per year, so 63 days of basic. Saudi Arabia: half a month's full wage per year, but a resignation between two and five years gives you one third. Qatar: three weeks of basic per year. Work it out with your own numbers — the chapters give the formulas.

Can I change jobs in the UAE?

Yes, under the rules for transfer and after the notice period in your contract, and normally with the current employer's agreement or at the end of the contract term. The MoHRE-registered contract is what the labour office will read.

What happens if my employer takes my passport?

It is unlawful across the Gulf. Report it to your embassy and the labour office in writing, and call the OWRC helpline. Do not wait for the situation to resolve itself.

Do I need to pay tax in India on my Gulf salary?

Generally not, if you are a non-resident and the salary is earned and received abroad. The 182-day rule decides residence. Once you are resident and ordinarily resident, your global income comes into scope — which is why the year of return needs planning.

Is PBBY worth it if I am not ECR?

Yes. Rs. 375 for three years buys Rs. 10 lakh of accidental death and permanent disability cover. It is the cheapest protection available and most people never tell their family it exists.

What if the contract I am given abroad is different from the one I signed in India?

Refuse to sign the substituted version and contact the embassy the same day. A substituted contract is one of the clearest signs of a fraudulent placement, and signing it converts the fraud into your consent.

Can my wife work in the Gulf?

In the UAE and Qatar, dependants can take up employment with a permit. In Saudi Arabia, dependants generally cannot work. Check the current rule for your country before planning a second income.

How much money should I bring for the first month?

Enough for rent, food, transport and a phone for 30–45 days, because the first salary can lag arrival. Rs. 15,000–40,000 equivalent is the realistic range, more if your accommodation is not provided.

Is it better to go through a big agent or a small one?

It is better to go through a licensed one whose registration you have verified, whose invoice you hold, and whose name matches the entity that receives your money. Size is not the test; traceability is.

What is the single most useful thing to do before signing?

Read the basic salary line and multiply it by 21 and divide by 30, once per year of service. That number is your gratuity. If it is small, negotiate the basic, not the total.

A closing note

The Gulf has taken Indian workers for fifty years and will take them for fifty more. What has changed is that the information is now available to you before you pay anyone — the agent's licence, the employer's registration, the labour law, the fee ceiling, the insurance you are owed. The people who do well are not the ones with the best agent. They are the ones who checked. That is the whole book.

Rules change. Check the official page before you decide, keep every receipt, and keep your family informed. If something feels wrong at the airport, it is wrong.